

No election

In October 1955, Diem staged a referendum in which he defeated Bao Dai, making himself president of the Republic of Vietnam. Diem had no intention of allowing the nationwide elections provided for in the Geneva Accords to take place—neither he nor the United States had ratified the accords. The United States was happy to supply money and equipment to a man who had shown he could use it effectively, to suppress troublesome factions and keep communism at bay.

Consolidating power

Diem's successful creation of a US-backed police state in the South was an uncomfortable surprise to Ho Chi Minh and his colleagues. They had counted on the weakness of South Vietnam to allow the unification of Vietnam under communist rule, with or without elections being held.

At first, Ho Chi Minh was preoccupied with establishing a monopoly of power in North Vietnam. Noncommunist nationalists who had fought under the banner of the Viet Minh were executed or sent to labor camps, and the communist party line was drilled into the entire population through propaganda and the use of terror against those who disagreed. In the countryside, revolt triggered by the introduction of a land reform program was crushed by force, leading to hundreds of thousands of deaths. Yet the North Vietnamese government had the advantage of being perceived as a Vietnamese regime. Diem, on the other hand, was seen as continuing the era of foreign influence in Vietnam by allowing the Americans to replace the French.



Mailing propaganda

A South Vietnamese postage stamp issued in 1955 shows refugees fleeing North Vietnam. The decision of many thousands of Vietnamese to move south rather than live under communism inspired anticommunist propaganda.